

Chapter 11

The Lie

The next morning...

Elara arrived at Northbridge earlier than usual.

She had barely slept.

Roman's message was still somewhere in the back of her mind.

Still hate me?

She had saved his number the night before.

But she hadn't replied.

Not yet.

She placed her bag on the desk and opened her laptop.

She tried to focus.

For a few minutes, it worked.

Then the door opened.

Ethan walked in.

"Morning."

Elara didn't look up.

"Morning."

He stood there for a moment.

"You didn't answer my calls last night."

"I was tired."

"You could've at least replied."

Elara finally looked at him.

"I didn't feel like talking."

Ethan studied her face.

"Is this about Roman?"

Her expression changed.

"Why would you ask that?"

"Because you've been acting differently since yesterday."

Elara closed her laptop.

"You know what, Ethan?"

"What?"

"I'm starting to wonder how much you actually knew."

Ethan went quiet.

"About what?"

"Don't."

Her voice was calm, but there was something underneath it.

"You told me he was dead."

"I told you what I knew."

"No."

Elara stood.

"You told me he was gone."

"You made me believe there was nothing left to question."

Ethan's jaw tightened.

"Elara, I was trying to protect you."

"From what?"

He didn't answer.

She laughed bitterly.

"Exactly."

"Three years, Ethan."

"I spent three years hating someone I thought was dead."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"You do."

Her eyes filled slightly, but she refused to look away.

"You knew something."

Ethan sighed.

"Some things aren't that simple."

"Then make them simple."

She stepped closer.

"Tell me the truth."

"I can't."

Elara stared at him.

The words hurt more than she expected.

"You can't?"

"Or you won't?"

Ethan remained silent.

She shook her head.

"I trusted you."

"I know."

"No."

Her voice softened.

"You don't."

She looked away.

"I trusted you enough to believe you without asking questions."

A pause.

"And maybe that was my mistake."

Ethan's expression changed.

"Elara..."

She picked up the folder on her desk.

"I have a meeting."

"With Veyron?"

"Yes."

He looked at her carefully.

"Are you sure you can handle that?"

Elara gave him a tired smile.

"It's a business meeting."

"Nothing more."

She walked past him.

As she reached the door, she stopped.

"At least..."

she said quietly,

"that's what I'm going to believe."

A few hours later...

Elara sat in the back seat of the car heading toward Veyron's headquarters.

She looked out of the window.

Frankfurt passed quietly outside.

She kept telling herself the same thing.

It's just a meeting.

We're not going to work together.

It's probably only a formality.

Stay calm.

She repeated it until the words almost stopped meaning anything.

When the car stopped outside Veyron's headquarters, she took a slow breath.

Then stepped out.

The building stood tall against the Frankfurt skyline.

Everything about it looked controlled.

Elegant.

Powerful.

Elara walked inside.

She kept her expression composed as she was escorted to the executive floor.

The doors opened.

She stepped into Roman's office.

And there he was.

Roman stood near the windows.

Dark suit.

White shirt.

His posture relaxed.

His expression calm.

There was something striking about him.

Not because he was trying to impress anyone.

He simply didn't need to.

The kind of confidence that came from knowing exactly who he was.

Roman turned.

Their eyes met.

For a brief second...

Elara forgot what she was about to say.

Then she reminded herself.

Business.

Nothing else.

"Good afternoon."

Roman nodded.

"Good afternoon."

They took their seats.

The meeting began.
Investment figures.
Development plans.
Construction timelines.
Future expansion.
Elara asked questions.
Roman answered them calmly.
Neither mentioned the past.
Neither mentioned Noah.
Neither mentioned the years between them.
And Elara was relieved.
Maybe Ethan had been right about one thing.
Maybe this really could remain professional.
By the end of the meeting, Roman pushed a file toward her.
"These are the revised terms."
Elara opened it.
She read through the first few pages.
"The investment percentage has changed."
"Yes."
"Why?"
"We believe the revised structure benefits both companies."
Elara studied the numbers.
It was a strong proposal.
Too strong to dismiss.
She closed the file.
"I'll review it with my father."
Roman nodded.
"Of course."
She stood.
"Thank you for your time."
"Likewise."
Elara turned toward the door.
She didn't look back.
Not once.

The moment she got into the car...
she closed the door.
"Water."
Her voice came out quickly.
The driver handed her a bottle.
She opened it and drank several hurried sips.
Then stopped.
She placed the bottle against her knee.
Her breathing was faster than normal.
She closed her eyes.
"It's nothing."
She whispered to herself.
"It's just a meeting."
She took another breath.
"Calm down."
Her fingers tightened around the bottle.
"You knew this was going to happen."
Another breath.
"Nothing happened."
She opened her eyes.
"Nothing."
She looked out the window.
But deep inside...
she knew that wasn't completely true.
Because for three years, Roman had existed only as a memory.
Today...
he had been sitting directly across from her.
Alive.
Calm.
And completely different from the person she had spent years hating.

That evening...
Elara returned home.

She expected a quiet dinner.

Instead, her father was already waiting at the table.

"How was the meeting?"

"Fine."

"Did Roman agree to the revised proposal?"

Elara looked up.

"You already knew about it?"

Her father nodded.

"Of course."

She sat down.

For a few moments, neither spoke.

Then her father said,

"We've decided to move forward with the deal."

Elara slowly looked at him.

"What?"

"The Veyron investment."

Her expression changed.

"You agreed?"

"Yes."

She stared at him.

"But you said..."

Her voice became quieter.

"You said he was dead."

Her father sighed.

"Elara..."

"No."

She shook her head.

"You can't just say his name like this is normal."

"This is business."

"For you."

Her voice trembled.

"Not for me."

Her father put his fork down.

"Veyron has been at the top of the market for the past seven months."

"This company has expanded rapidly."

"Their current position is something we cannot ignore."

"So that's it?"

Elara laughed softly, but there was no happiness in it.

"Seven months of success is enough to erase everything?"

"No one is erasing anything."

"Then what are you doing?"

Her voice rose.

"You knew what Roman meant to me."

"You knew what I believed."

"You knew I thought he was dead."

"And today..."

She swallowed hard.

"Today you sent me into a room with him and expected me to discuss investment percentages."

Her father looked at her.

"Because you are the director of this company."

Elara stared at him.

For a moment, she looked more hurt than angry.

"That's all I am?"

"What?"

"The director."

"The daughter who is supposed to sit there, smile, sign papers and forget everything else?"

"Elara, that's not what I'm saying."

"It is."

Her eyes filled with tears.

"You don't understand what it was like."

"I woke up every day believing he was gone."

"I hated him."

Her voice shook.

"I hated him because I thought he was responsible for everything."

"And now I find out..."

She stopped.

Her breathing became uneven.

"I find out he was alive."

Her father remained silent.

"And you want me to work with him."

"Yes."

The word landed heavily.

Elara looked at him.

There was pain in her eyes now.

Not just anger.

Something deeper.

"I don't know what's worse."

Her father frowned.

"What?"

"That Roman is alive..."

She wiped away a tear.

"Or that everyone I trusted knew something I didn't."

Her father stood.

"Ethan may have had reasons."

Elara immediately looked at him.

"Don't defend him."

"I'm not defending anyone."

"You are."

Her voice broke.

"I trusted Ethan more than anyone."

"I believed him."

"I believed every word he told me."

"And now I don't even know if the person I trusted most was telling me the truth."

Her father tried to calm her.

"Elara, you can't let this destroy your judgment."

"My judgment?"

She stared at him.

"My whole life changed because of what you people told me."

She pushed her chair back.

"You all decided what I should know."

"What I should believe."

"And now you're deciding who I should work with."

"Because of a deal."

Her father raised his voice.

"Because I have a responsibility to this company!"

Elara flinched.

Then looked at him through tears.

"And I have a responsibility to myself."

Silence.

She took a shaky breath.

"If you want this deal..."

Her voice became quieter.

"Then fine."

"But if something happens..."

She looked directly into his eyes.

"If this decision brings something into our lives that you can't control..."

A tear slipped down her cheek.

"Then don't come to me later and say you didn't know."

Her father said nothing.

Elara continued.

"I trusted Ethan."

"He broke that trust."

"I trusted you."

Her voice cracked.

"And tonight..."

She shook her head.

"I don't know if I can trust you either."

Her father looked at her.

"Elara..."

But she was already standing.

She turned and walked upstairs.

Her father called after her.

"Elara!"

She didn't stop.

She entered her room.

Closed the door.

Locked it.

Then leaned against it.

Her tears finally fell.

She covered her mouth, trying to keep herself quiet.

Outside...

the house remained silent.

Inside...

Elara whispered through tears,

"I just wanted the truth."

And for the first time...

she wondered whether knowing the truth would hurt even more than the lie.